WAVERLEY GATEWAY GUIDE

Connecting International Capital with Emerging & Frontier Markets

LIBERIA

Africa

Information current as of October 2026

Dialogue | Trust | Partnership

office@lordwaverley.com
www.lordwaverley.com

WHERE AND HOW TO ENTER

KEY INVESTMENT LOCATIONS

Location / Region	Strategic Importance	Priority Sectors
Monrovia and the Freeport of Monrovia	Capital and main commercial port, now operating around the clock after night navigation was restored in 2026; home to the Monrovia Freezone and Monrovia Industrial Park	Trade, logistics, services, light manufacturing
Nimba County (Yekepa / Tokadeh)	Iron ore heartland, where ArcelorMittal's Tokadeh concentrator is lifting shipments from about 5 to 20 million tonnes a year in 2026	Iron ore mining, mining services, power
Buchanan (Grand Bassa County)	Rail terminus and ore-export port gaining an additional berth, and site of the 200-hectare, AfDB-funded Buchanan Special Agro-Processing Zone	Port logistics, agro-processing, mining services
Yekepa–Buchanan rail corridor	Multi-user corridor being upgraded to carry up to 30 million tonnes a year, with Ivanhoe Atlantic set to ship Guinean ore from 2027 and an independent rail operator planned from 2030	Rail, cross-border mining logistics, engineering
Grand Cape Mount County (Bea Mountain)	Liberia's leading gold-mining district, centred on the New Liberty operation and its satellite mines	Gold mining, mining services, local supply
Margibi County / Roberts International Airport	International air gateway, recently upgraded, with the Roberts International Special Zone nearby and a rubber belt now oriented towards domestic processing	Aviation, logistics, rubber processing
Offshore Liberia Basin	Frontier oil and gas acreage, with eight exploration blocks awarded to TotalEnergies and Oranto and around $800 million of expected investment	Oil and gas exploration, offshore services

INVESTOR ENTRY ROUTES

- National Investment Commission (NIC), the investment promotion agency administering the Investment Act of 2010, screening projects and granting incentives such as customs duty relief under the 2021 Tax Amendment Act

- Concession and investment agreements reviewed by the Inter-Ministerial Concession Committee; contracts of $10 million or more are ratified by the Legislature and approved by the President, giving them the force of law (e.g. the ArcelorMittal agreement, extended to 2050)
- Liberia Special Economic Zones Authority (operational since 2024) overseeing five zones, including the Buchanan Special Agro-Processing Zone, Monrovia Freezone, Monrovia Industrial Park and Roberts International Special Zone
- Dual-currency system in which the US dollar and Liberian dollar are both legal tender, with 100% repatriation of funds and no currency exchange restrictions
- Additional incentives for projects in economically deprived regions, those creating more than 100 direct jobs and those using at least 60% local materials, with priority sectors including agro-processing, energy, manufacturing, tourism, ICT and housing
- Wholly foreign-owned companies permitted with minimum capital of $500,000 (or $300,000 with at least 25% Liberian ownership); land is held through leases, typically of 25 to 50 years
- Petroleum entry through production-sharing contracts awarded by the Liberia Petroleum Regulatory Agency, supported by ICSID, New York Convention and MIGA membership for dispute resolution and risk cover

MARKET-ENTRY OBSERVATION

Liberia in October 2026 is one of West Africa's steadier growth stories, anchored by a mining expansion and a disciplined IMF-supported reform programme. Real GDP grew 5.1% in 2025, up from 4.0% in 2024, as mining output rose 17% and exports climbed 31.5%; the IMF projects 5.5% growth in 2026. Inflation fell to 4% by December 2025 and is estimated at 4.5% in Q3 2026, allowing the Central Bank of Liberia to trim its policy rate to 16%, while gross international reserves now cover 3.3 months of imports, above the ECOWAS benchmark. The IMF completed its fourth review under the Extended Credit Facility on 28 September 2026, alongside a new $265 million Resilience and Sustainability Facility. Investment momentum is strong: ArcelorMittal's agreement has been extended to 2050 with a $1.8 billion expansion to 20 million tonnes a year, Ivanhoe Atlantic has secured a $1.8 billion rail-and-port access deal, and TotalEnergies and Oranto have taken up eight offshore blocks. Inward FDI reached $744.7 million in 2023 (17.1% of GDP), much of it in mining.

Liberia's main structural challenge is infrastructure. Electricity access is around 40% and only about one-fifth of the road network is paved, which raises costs for business; the end of major US aid in 2025 has also reduced grant funding. The government is responding with a clear programme. More than 63,000 new electricity connections were made in 2025, with 100,000 targeted in 2026; a 250 MW gas-to-power plant, a 200 MW solar plant with storage and a St. John River hydropower project are planned to take capacity above 700 MW; and a second Millennium Challenge Corporation compact focused on energy is in development. Roads are being paved through public-private concessions, and record domestic revenue of $847.7 million in 2025, a primary surplus and a planned move to VAT in 2027 are strengthening public finances. For investors, the infrastructure gap is itself a substantial opportunity in power generation, grids, roads, ports and logistics.

INVESTOR RISK & MARKET ACCESS

KEY ENTRY BARRIERS

Issue	Potential Impact	Possible Mitigation
Power and transport infrastructure	Electricity access is about 40% and only around 20% of roads are paved, which raises operating and logistics costs	Plan for captive or hybrid power; the 700 MW generation pipeline, the MCC energy compact and road concessions open opportunities for IPPs and infrastructure investors
Concentration on mining	Mining drove about 65% of growth in the first three quarters of 2025, so output and revenue track iron ore and gold prices	Long-term agreements and multi-user rail add stability, while the rubber processing drive and agro-processing zones are opening diversified entry points
Lower donor grant funding	The end of major US aid in 2025 reduced grant financing for social programmes	IMF ECF and RSF support, record domestic revenue and planned VAT are filling the gap; social-sector investors can partner with the World Bank, AfDB and EU Global Gateway
Governance and contract enforcement	Liberia rose to 135th of 180 in the 2024	Use legislatively ratified agreements with

Issue	Potential Impact	Possible Mitigation
	Corruption Perceptions Index (from 145th), but commercial court cases can be slow	international arbitration under ICSID and the New York Convention, and robust compliance procedures
Land tenure	Only about 25% of land is formally registered, foreigners lease rather than own land, and community land claims can arise	Conduct early title due diligence with the Liberia Land Authority and agree community benefits under the 2018 Land Rights Act
Banking sector depth	Non-performing loans are 13.4%, above the 10% benchmark, though banks hold capital adequacy of 38.6% and liquidity of 58.7%	Bank restructuring under the IMF programme is under way; larger projects can draw on DFI finance such as DFC and AfDB facilities
Ownership thresholds and reserved sectors	Certain retail and service activities are reserved for Liberians, and minimum capital rules apply to foreign-owned firms	Partner with Liberian firms where required, which also supports local-content and community expectations

INVESTOR RISK NOTE

Liberia's risk profile is that of a fast-improving frontier market with strengthening macroeconomic anchors. Growth has accelerated to above 5%, inflation has fallen to mid-single digits, reserves have risen to 3.3 months of import cover and the IMF programme has stayed on track through four reviews, with a new Resilience and Sustainability Facility adding support. Long-dated, legislatively ratified agreements such as ArcelorMittal's to 2050 and Ivanhoe Atlantic's 25-year rail access give major investors a clear legal basis, backed by ICSID and New York Convention membership. The main practical considerations are infrastructure costs, land due diligence, contract enforcement and a still-developing banking sector, each of which can be managed through captive power, careful structuring, international arbitration clauses and DFI co-finance. The widespread use of the US dollar and full freedom to repatriate funds reduce currency risk for investors, and Liberia's peaceful democratic transition in 2023 and its election to the UN Security Council for 2026–2027 underline its growing stability and international standing.

MARKET ACCESS

Liberia is a member of the Economic Community of West African States (ECOWAS), applying its Common External Tariff and giving preferential access to the wider West African market, and of the Mano River Union with Guinea, Sierra Leone and Côte d'Ivoire. It ratified the African Continental Free Trade Area (AfCFTA) in 2023 and has launched a national implementation strategy for 2025–2030, and it has been a WTO member since 14 July 2016. Liberia qualifies for duty-free US access under AGOA, which was renewed in 2026, and the United States is its largest export market (about 38% of exports), followed by Europe and Ghana. Iron ore moves by rail to Buchanan, and the Yekepa–Buchanan corridor is becoming a regional gateway for Guinean ore. Liberia also operates the world's largest ship registry, approaching 300 million gross tons and around 17% of global shipping capacity, which gives it unusual global maritime reach.

WHO SHOULD THE INVESTOR MEET?

INSTITUTIONAL LANDSCAPE

Actor	Why It Matters	Waverley Engagement Angle
Office of the President (Joseph Nyuma Boakai)	Leads the ARREST Agenda for Inclusive Development (2025–2029) and approves major concession agreements	Primary reference point for strategic priorities and flagship projects
National Investment Commission (NIC)	Investment promotion agency administering the Investment Act and incentives, now chaired by Morley P. Kamara	Standard first point of contact for market entry, incentives and investor facilitation
Central Bank of Liberia (Governor Henry F. Saamoi)	Sets monetary policy, manages reserves and supervises banks in a dual-currency system	Relevant for currency, banking and financial-services matters
Ministry of Finance and Development Planning (Minister Augustine Kpehe	Manages the budget, the IMF programme, tax reform and the second MCC compact	Key counterpart for fiscal incentives, PPPs and donor-aligned projects

Actor	Why It Matters	Waverley Engagement Angle
Ngafuan)		
Ministry of Mines and Energy	Oversees mineral rights and the power sector, including the generation pipeline and mining concessions	Essential partner for mining, mining-services and energy investment
Liberia Petroleum Regulatory Agency	Licenses and regulates upstream oil and gas, including the 2024 direct-negotiation round	Gateway for offshore exploration and related services
National Port Authority and Liberia Special Economic Zones Authority	Manage the country's ports and its five special economic zones	Relevant for logistics, port services and zone-based manufacturing or agro-processing

CURRENT INTERNATIONAL BUSINESS CHANNELS

The Liberia Chamber of Commerce is the main domestic business association and an active voice on local content, while the National Investment Commission leads investor outreach. The EU–Liberia Business Forum held in Brussels in February 2026 showcased around €1.5 billion of opportunities in agriculture, energy, infrastructure, mining, fisheries and tourism under the EU's Global Gateway strategy, and Liberia sent its first-ever delegation to the World Economic Forum in Davos in January 2026. Development finance is an important channel: the US International Development Finance Corporation has more than $90 million in active commitments, the World Bank signed $125 million of infrastructure and electricity financing in June 2026, the AfDB financed the Buchanan agro-processing zone, and the Millennium Challenge Corporation is preparing an energy-focused second compact. Major operators such as ArcelorMittal and Ivanhoe Atlantic are also valuable sources of practical insight on mining logistics.

INVESTOR PROFILE BEST SUITED

Liberia suits investors with a frontier-market appetite and a long-term horizon: mining and mining-services firms positioned around the iron ore and gold expansion and the multi-user rail corridor; power developers and infrastructure investors targeting generation, grid and road concessions, often alongside DFIs and the MCC; agribusiness and agro-processing investors in rubber, palm oil and cocoa, supported by the new rubber processing policy and the Buchanan zone; logistics and port operators; and oil and gas services firms preparing for offshore exploration. The use of the US dollar and full repatriation freedom make the market particularly accessible for dollar-based investors.

FROM INTELLIGENCE TO ENGAGEMENT

STEP 1: Engage the National Investment Commission early
Open dialogue with the NIC to confirm eligibility, incentive terms and any ownership thresholds for your sector before structuring the investment.

STEP 2: Secure a ratified agreement for larger projects
For investments of $10 million or more, negotiate through the concession process so that terms are ratified by the Legislature and include international arbitration.

STEP 3: Build power and logistics solutions into the business case
Plan for captive or hybrid power and assess rail, port and road access, while tracking the MCC compact and new generation projects that will lower costs.

STEP 4: Complete land and community due diligence
Verify title with the Liberia Land Authority, structure long leases and agree community benefits at the outset to secure a stable operating base.

STEP 5: Partner with DFIs and use special economic zones
Combine DFC, World Bank, AfDB or EU Global Gateway support with zone incentives, particularly at Buchanan, for agro-processing, manufacturing and infrastructure projects.